

Forty-One Lines

The principle. Krish cannot bear a fact wrong in front of a room. Asked to be best man for his mate Dev, he had Code Overlord build him Bestmanship, which writes you a best man's speech with nothing wrong in it. His went so well that he had Code Overlord make it for every best man in Britain, and then teach it to give everybody the lines that got the laughs. By August every best man in the country was giving the same speech, with his own groom's name in it, and the rooms knew it better than the best men did.

Why it is funny. A man who cannot stand one wrong fact builds the machine that gives every wedding in Britain the same speech, until the room can do it without the best man, and at his own wedding the whole room shouts something about him that never happened. Every step works exactly as he asked, and he is delighted with all of it.

On the fridge, the invitation: DEV AND SIMRAN, 17 JUNE 2028.

At Krish's brother's wedding, the best man called the bride by her sister's name. All the way through.

"Did the best man ever find out?"

"No." A pause. "I think about it in the car."

Now Krish is Dev's best man.

"I said to Code Overlord, 'Build me something that writes a best man's speech with nothing wrong in it.' By the morning it had built me Bestmanship." A pause. "I named it."

Forty-one lines, every one checked against his photos and messages. The wedding. Line thirty.

"And then Dev fell in the canal at Gas Street Basin, holding a kebab." A pause. "On a Thursday."

Dev's nan laughed so hard she had to be walked out to the car park.

"Why was that the laugh?"

"I don't know." A pause. "I'd checked it."

By the cake, a queue of lads wanted a copy.

"So I went back to Code Overlord. Make it for anybody."

Orange cue cards in the post, bestmanship.com along the bottom. Then the emails.

"Is it funny, though?' So, back to Code Overlord. Give everybody the lines that get a laugh."

A phone by every best man's pint, listening. Whatever got a laugh at one wedding, every best man had by the next.

"By August there was one speech."

"Whose?"

"Mine." A pause. "It's very good."

"Did people get bored of it?"

"They got word perfect."

A wedding in Swindon. A man on the top table stood up with his pint.

"We KNOW, you [BLEEP]!"

"Who was that?"

"The groom."

Bestmanship logged it as a laugh.

"Line thirty was the best line in Britain. Everybody wanted it, with their own groom in."

Saturday, a wedding in Walsall.

"And then Wayne fell in the canal at Gas Street Basin, holding a kebab."

The room: "ON A THURSDAY!"

Saturday, a golf club in Cardiff.

"And then..."

The room: "EWAN FELL IN THE CANAL AT GAS STREET BASIN, HOLDING A KEBAB, ON A THURSDAY!"

The best man in Cardiff sits down.

Now Krish is getting married. Dev's his best man. Dev stands up with one orange card, and the room gets there first.

"AND THEN KRISH FELL IN THE CANAL AT GAS STREET BASIN, HOLDING A KEBAB, ON A THURSDAY!"

Dev sits down.

"Any regrets?"

"None. Code Overlord built me Bestmanship in a night, and there's not been a wrong word at a British wedding since."

"Have you ever been in the canal?"

A long pause. "No." A pause. "I think about it in the car."

The card comes up. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence said out loud to the laptop, the terminals starting, and by morning Bestmanship exists. Every rung after that is the same thing again: another plain sentence to Code Overlord, and by morning Bestmanship can do one more thing. "Give

everybody the lines that get a laugh" is a Ritual, a prompt on a cadence, in a terminal anyone could watch rewriting every speech in Britain after every Saturday. Everything Bestmanship does in the world is bought and ordinary: a website, orange cue cards in the post, a phone by a pint.

Accent. The whole cast is Birmingham: Krish, Dev, Dev's nan, the man in Swindon, the best man and the room in Walsall, and the room at Krish's wedding. The best man and the room in Cardiff are the only other voices, one line each. It lives in the vowels and the rhythm, never in the spelling; Krish's flat "I think about it in the car" is the whole of Birmingham in eight words. The interviewer stays the house voice.

Three things to decide. The ending: it closes on Krish's own wedding, the room shouting line thirty about him before Dev can speak, and "I think about it in the car", which pays off the opening. The canal: in the long version every groom in Britain is sent into the canal to make line thirty true, up to the Prime Minister and Krish himself. It was cut here as a second joke that needs its chain explaining; the long version keeps it whole. "Keep it short, our kid": the long version plants it at the top, and Dev's one card at the end would pay it off, for about ten words.

Condensed from a longer version that went through two comedians' panels, then checked against its essence; the long version is kept.